The Memory Cycle Journal

LEAD STORY KEY NUMBERS FROM THE INBOX ON X CYCLE TRACKER EVENTS

KOSPI (INTRADAY, 13:00 KST)
5,706.14 +2.76% · Samsung +5.08% · SK hynix +4.25% · Tue close 5,552.74 (−3.73%) · SOX Tue −0.29%

DDR5 16GB SPOT
$60.77 +0.11% · TrendForce 2026-10-21 11:00 GMT+8 · DDR4 16Gb $83.117 (−0.30%) · no new NAND spot print

LEAD STORY

KOREA · EXPORTS AND THE TAPE

Korea's Chip Exports More Than Triple in Early October as Seoul's Chipmakers Bounce Back

Customs data show record chip shipments for the first 20 days of the month. A blowout preliminary quarter from Supermicro sent Samsung and SK hynix up about 8% at one point before they gave back part of the gain.

By the Memory Cycle Desk · Tel Aviv · Data as of ~08:20 IDT · Korea prices intraday · CONFIRMED unless marked

KEY NUMBERS · THE CYCLE IN NUMBERS

KOREA EXPORTS, OCT 1–20

Chips (y/y)	**$27.5B (+222.5%)**
Chips per working day	**$2.12B**
Chip share of exports	**44.7%**

Q4 CONTRACT, Q/Q (COMMERCIAL TIMES)

DRAM / NAND	**+20% / +30%**
DRAM Q2 / Q3 for comparison	**~80% / ~40%**

SK HYNIX (CHOSUN BIZ)

Q3 OP consensus	**₩76.96T (−5.6% in 3 mo)**
HBM revenue share Q1→Q2	**58% → 50%**

DEMAND / MARKET

Supermicro Q1 prelim vs guide	**$18.5–19.5B vs $14.5–15.5B**
MU Tue / after hours	**−0.98% / +2.13%**

Sources: Korea Customs Service via The Korea Times and trade.aljal.kr; Commercial Times via TrendForce; Chosun Biz; Supermicro; stockanalysis.com.

Korea's chip exports rose **222.5% from a year earlier to $27.5 billion** in the first 20 days of October, a record for the period, and made up **44.7%** of all exports, the Korea Customs Service said. Total exports were a record $61.6 billion (The Korea Times). Per working day, chip exports averaged **$2.12 billion**, a little below the $2.22 billion of Oct. 1–10 and the $2.20 billion of Sept. 1–20 (customs data compiled by trade.aljal.kr).

The stocks bounced. After closing down **3.73%** on Tuesday at 5,552.74, with Samsung off 2.98% and SK hynix 4.23% (Yonhap), the Kospi rose more than 5% on Wednesday morning, triggering the first buy-side program-trading halt since Aug. 20 (Seoul Economic Daily). By 13:00 the index was up **2.76% at 5,706.14**, with Samsung up 5.08% and SK hynix 4.25%. Foreigners were net buyers of ₩423 billion while individuals sold ₩987 billion (Global Economic). The trigger came from the U.S.: after Tuesday's close Supermicro said fiscal first-quarter revenue would be **$18.5–19.5 billion, against guidance of $14.5–15.5 billion**. Micron, down 0.98% to $896.07 in regular trading, rose 2.13% after hours.

Contract prices are still rising, but more slowly. Commercial Times reports institutional investors expect fourth-quarter contract prices up about **20% for DRAM and 30% for NAND**, against roughly 80% in the second quarter and 40% in the third. It cites the high base, weaker end-market buying power and LTA price ceilings (TrendForce). That is above TrendForce's own Sept. 30 guide of 10–15% for conventional DRAM and 15–20% for NAND. A Jefferies semis sales note called it "way more than buyside expects."

Our call: late upcycle, tight through 2027, unchanged; a touch tighter on demand evidence, while the rate of price increase keeps slowing. CYCLE SIGNAL: DEMAND FIRM, ROC SLOWING

HBM · MARKET SHARE

SK Hynix's HBM4 Shipments Fall Short Again as Samsung Narrows the Gap



Photo: News1 via Chosun Biz

The industry believes SK hynix's HBM4 shipments missed expectations in the third quarter, as they did in the second. Reasons cited are a partial delay to Nvidia's Rubin and longer-than-expected tuning of mass-production parts (Chosun Biz). Third-quarter operating-profit consensus is **₩76.96 trillion** (a 78.4% margin), down 5.6% from three months ago. Counterpoint puts SK hynix's HBM revenue share at **50% in the second quarter, down from 58%**, while Samsung rose to 33% from 21%. JPMorgan sees SK hynix's share at 46% this year and 41% in 2027. UBS expects Samsung to pass SK hynix in 2027 HBM bits, 41% to 39%. Samsung's HBM4 yield is believed to be about 80%. This moves share between suppliers more than it changes total demand. SK hynix reports on Oct. 28 and Samsung on Oct. 29. CYCLE SIGNAL: SHARE, NOT DEMAND

FROM THE INBOX · SINCE OCT 20, 08:10 IDT

NEW **Q4 hikes "way more than buyside expects."** Samsung: 5-year LTAs cover 70% of 2027E commodity output and annual contracts all of HBM; OP ₩367T (2026E) and ₩555T (2027E). DeMark buy setups forming on SOX, KOSPI, SK hynix and MU. Jefferies, Oct 20

NEW **Lead times still long.** TrendForce figures in the Jefferies memory-call agenda: DRAM ~20 weeks and NAND ~16, against ~8 normally. More than 1,000 have registered for Thursday's call. Jefferies via semis digest, Oct 21

NEW **Demand data, not opinion.** SpaceX guided Q4 capex to $35–40B and said it could not rent spare GPUs. BofA expects Google to raise the low end of FY26 capex by $5B to $200–205B "to cover higher memory prices." SECONDARY Semis digest, Oct 21

ON X · SINCE LAST EDITION

@pequityresearch
SK hynix HBM4 shipments short of expectations in Q3; Q3 OP consensus ₩76.96T (Korean press).
x.com/.../2112726335558693089

@RealNickMugalli SECONDARY
Nomura: memory supply constraints persist through at least 2028; Buy Samsung and SK hynix.
x.com/.../2112467773846892702

@Schulz_Research
TrendForce's Sept 30 guide is lower (DRAM +10–15%, NAND +15–20%): "Curious whose numbers the 20% and 30% are."
x.com/.../2112537016017854600

@Schulz_Research
At 288GB per GB300, 200,000 GPUs a month is roughly 58 petabytes of HBM a month for one customer (his math).
x.com/.../2112673661677445461

@jukan05
Groq, now owned by Nvidia, seeks 3D-stacked DRAM in next-gen chips (ZDNet Korea).
x.com/…/2112665161194672181

@dnystedt
Micron Taoyuan sympathy strike Thursday 10/22; the Taichung union will not strike that day.
x.com/…/2112433699258351730

X API posts; broker views relayed on X are secondary (notes not seen). Also: @jukan05 says Chinese phone brands are reusing old DRAM UNCONFIRMED.

CYCLE TRACKER

Unchanged: demand firmer, price increases still slowing

GAUGE	TODAY VS OCT 20 (KPI PLAYBOOK WATCH LIST)	NUDGE
Contract ROC	Q4 DRAM +20%, NAND +30% vs ~80% / ~40% in Q2 / Q3; above TF's 10–15% guide	**Slowing, above guide**
Spot vs contract	DDR5 $60.77 (+0.11%); DDR4 $83.12 (−0.30%) vs $50 last public contract	**Flat**
Demand / backlog	Chip exports +222.5% ($2.12B/day vs $2.20B Sep); SMCI ~$4B above guide; OEM backlog +20–30%	**Firmer**
Lead times	DRAM ~20 wks, NAND ~16 vs ~8 normal (TrendForce)	**Tight**
HBM	SKH HBM4 short again; Samsung 33% share, ~80% yield	**Share shift**
Valuation / flows	Kospi +2.8% with foreign buying after −3.7%; memory makers −42% from highs (JPM)	**Pricing a downturn**

VERDICT
Late upcycle; tight through 2027, unchanged. A touch tighter: Korea's chip exports more than tripled in early October, Supermicro beat its own guidance by about $4 billion, and DRAM lead times are still about 20 weeks. The rate of price increase keeps slowing, though: fourth-quarter DRAM contracts are seen up about 20%, half the third quarter's gain, and spot is flat. SK hynix's HBM4 slip moves share to Samsung but doesn't change total demand. Seoul bounced on Wednesday after Tuesday's rout.

EVENTS CALENDAR · OCT 21–NOV 3 · ISRAEL TIME

When	Event	Watch
Wed 21	Nvidia GTC Berlin keynote 12:00 · Lam Research, Meta, TI AMC (Lam call 00:00 Thu)	WFE / capex
Thu 22	BoK · Micron Taichung talks + Taoyuan strike · Jefferies memory call 16:00 · WDC AMC	Supply / HDD
Tue 27	Seagate FQ1 AMC · Ultra Clean	HDD / memory capex
Wed 28	SK hynix 3Q26 02:00 · FOMC 20:00 · KLA, MSFT, GOOGL AMC	HBM / rates
Thu 29	Samsung 3Q26 03:00 · Sandisk, Intel, Amazon AMC	HBM / NAND
Fri 30 – Sun Nov 1	Kioxia, Tokyo Electron · CXMT Q3 (Oct 31) · Korea Oct exports (Nov 1 ~02:00)	NAND / China / exports

IDT to Oct 24, IST from Oct 25. Also: Supermicro final Q1 Nov 3; TrendForce month-end contract prices (date TBA); China export-catalog comments close Nov 15.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

- The Korea Times: Exports double in first 20 days of October on robust chip shipments
- Global Economic: Kospi touches 5,800 intraday; Samsung, SK hynix up 4%+ (Korean)
- Supermicro: Q1 FY2027 preliminary business update
- Seoul Economic Daily: KOSPI surge triggers first buy-side sidecar in two months
- Yonhap: Seoul stocks slide nearly 4 pct (Oct 20 close)
- TrendForce: DRAM prices seen rising 20% QoQ in 4Q26 despite slower gains

- ▸ TrendForce: 4Q26 contract price forecast (Sep 30)
- ▸ CNA: Micron Taichung mediation Oct 22, Taoyuan union strikes in support (Chinese)
- ▸ Chosun Biz: Samsung narrows SK hynix lead as HBM4 delays curb Korea chip gains